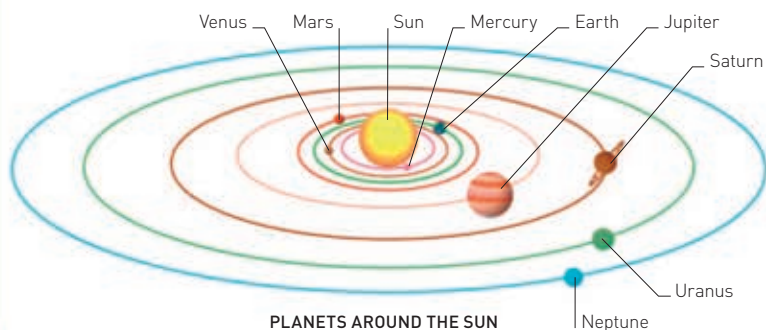


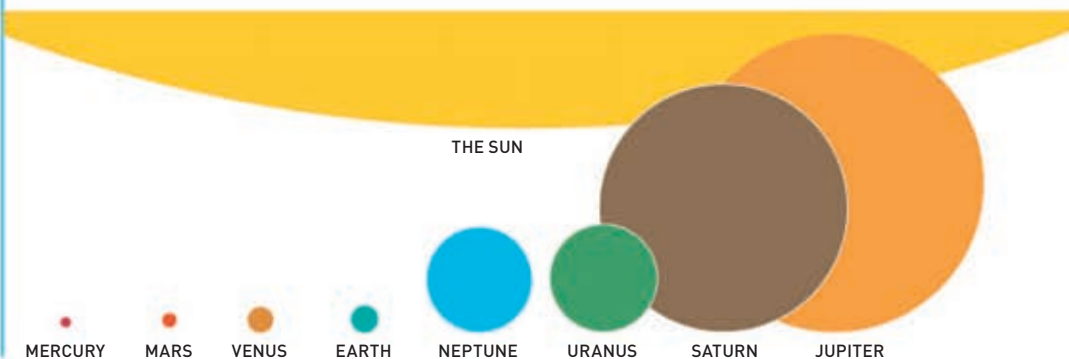
ORBITS

All of the planets orbit the Sun anticlockwise, in an elliptical, or oval pattern. This means they are closer to the Sun at some points in their orbits than others. They are trapped by the Sun's gravity and will stay in the same plane of orbit for ever.



PLANET SIZES

The four rocky planets nearest to the Sun are much smaller than the gas giants. The Sun dwarfs them all, but is itself much smaller than other stars in the Universe.



EARTH

Earth moves around the Sun at 30 km per second (18.6 miles per second) and takes 365 days to orbit it completely. It is the only planet known to have life on it.



HIMALAYAS
This mountain range was formed on Earth around 70 million years ago.

EARTH

ROCKY PLANET

DISTANCE FROM THE SUN: 152.6 million km (94.5 million miles)
DIAMETER: 12,756 km (7,926 miles)
TIME TAKEN TO ORBIT THE SUN: 365.26 Earth days
NUMBER OF MOONS: 1

MARS

The planet Mars is red, because its surface is covered in iron-rich dust and rock. It is about half the size of Earth and has both the highest mountain and the deepest valley of any planet in the Solar System.



OLYMPUS MONS
This mountain on Mars is about three times as tall as Earth's Mount Everest. It is also volcanic.

MARS

ROCKY PLANET

DISTANCE FROM THE SUN: 816 million km (507 million miles)
DIAMETER: 6,780 km (4,213 miles)
TIME TAKEN TO ORBIT THE SUN: 687 Earth days
NUMBER OF MOONS: 2

URANUS

Methane in Uranus's atmosphere gives it a rich blue colour. This planet is often called the "ice giant" because 80 per cent of it is made up of frozen methane, water, and ammonia.



RINGS
Uranus has very faint rings compared to the other gas giants.

URANUS

GAS GIANT

DISTANCE FROM THE SUN: 3 billion km (1.86 billion miles)
DIAMETER: 51,118 km (31,760 miles)
TIME TAKEN TO ORBIT THE SUN: 84.3 Earth years
NUMBER OF MOONS: 27

NEPTUNE

Neptune is the furthest planet from the Sun, so it gets little sunlight to warm its atmosphere. Its vivid blue colour is due to methane and an unknown compound. Neptune has the fastest winds in the Solar System.



GREAT DARK SPOT
This storm, which has now dispersed, was large enough to contain Earth, and moved at 1,200 km/h (750 mph).

NEPTUNE

GAS GIANT

DISTANCE FROM THE SUN: 4.5 billion km (2.8 billion miles)
DIAMETER: 49,528 km (30,775 miles)
TIME TAKEN TO ORBIT THE SUN: 168.4 Earth years
NUMBER OF MOONS: 14

URANUS

3,000 million km (1,864 million miles)

NEPTUNE

4,500 million km (2,796 million miles)